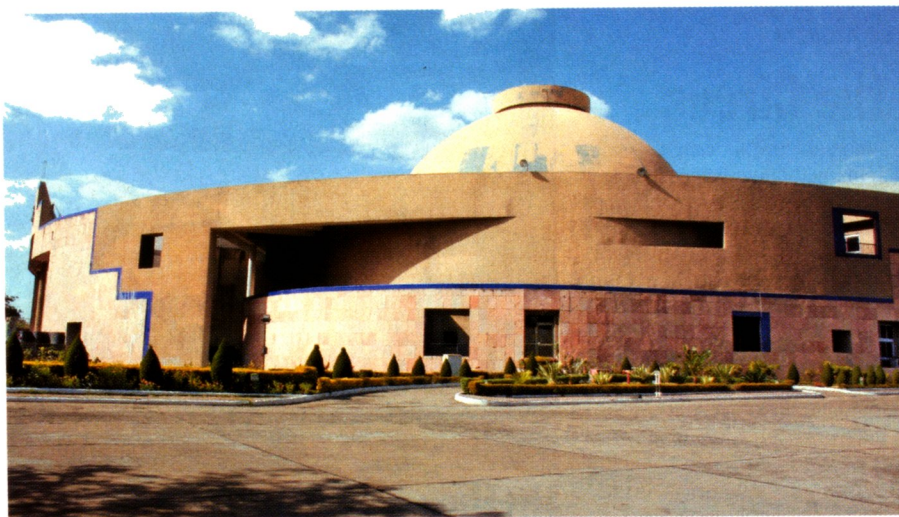




DEATHLY DESIGN

Over 20 deaths, mostly unnatural, of ministers and MLAs since the Assembly moved to new premises in the mid-'90s results in a clamour from legislators to correct the building's design

■ **By Ambresh Mishra**

It is an award-winning marvel of avant-garde architecture, not a dark, dank, dungeon-type structure associated with ghouls and goblins. But the architectural wonder that is the Madhya Pradesh Vidhan Sabha still spooks some legislators. A bunch of lawmakers fears that the assembly building, designed by renowned architect Charles Correa, is a virtual death trap. Twenty-one sitting MLAs have died since the Assembly shifted to its new hill-top address in the mid-'90s.

Apparently, legislators believe that vastu shastra, or the lack of it, in the lay-out and design has come to haunt the new building. The clamour for corrections in the design in accordance with the ancient Indian architectural and building code has become strong ever since school and college education minister and Indore's posterboy for Hindutva Laxman Singh Gaud died in a road accident on February 11. Just

days before Gaud's demise, a former minister in the BJP Government and MLA from Byohari constituency Kunwar Luvkesh Singh had died on February 8. During the past four years of the 12th term of the Vidhan Sabha, six of its sitting members have passed away. During the partial 10th term of the Vidhan Sabha in the new building, three sitting legislators died. The toll during the last term, the 11th, was 12.

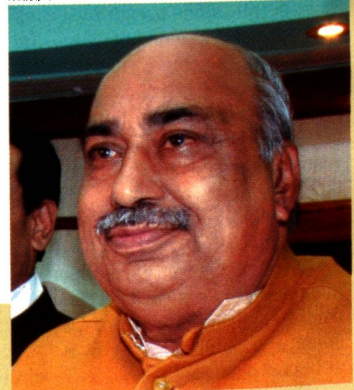
Some of these deaths have been especially violent. While another former minister and MLA from Pandhana, Kishorilal Verma was stabbed to death by a former member of his staff, Gaud met his end when the government-allotted Qualis he was riding rammed into a dumper on the Ashta-Dewas bypass road. At a special cabinet meeting convened in Bhopal on February 13 to condole Gaud's death, many ministers raised the issue of the perceived faults in the vastu of the building.

State Public Works Department Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya—who

last year demanded a ban on condoms being marketed by Hindustan Latex labelling them as sex toys—has already written to state Assembly Speaker Ishwardas Rohani in this regard. Says Vijayvargiya, "Top vastu shastris of the country should be invited to study the design and suggest remedial measures. We can then try to correct these anomalies as far as possible." Even the main opposition party, the Congress, and other parties are in agreement with the ruling party on this score.

The Samajwadi Party (SP), not

PANKAJ TIWARI



"Life and death are in the hands of the supreme power."

ISHWARDAS ROHANI, SPEAKER, MADHYA PRADESH ASSEMBLY